

1949–1959

WIVES AND MOTHERS

The postwar era saw advances in textiles and technology. Wash-and-wear fabrics appeared in the early 1950s, reducing time-consuming laundering.

Mass manufacturing, and the end of rationing in the UK, made a wider range of clothes available. At the same time, women were plunged back into traditional roles as home-makers. Glossy magazines advocated that women should look well turned out at all times, even when doing the housework. The house dress was especially significant as so much time was devoted to tasks in the home, at least for the majority of women who were not in paid employment. A typical day might include three hours of housework and an hour making the evening meal. For daily shopping trips into town, a smarter, more fitted, dress was recommended.

HANDBAGS

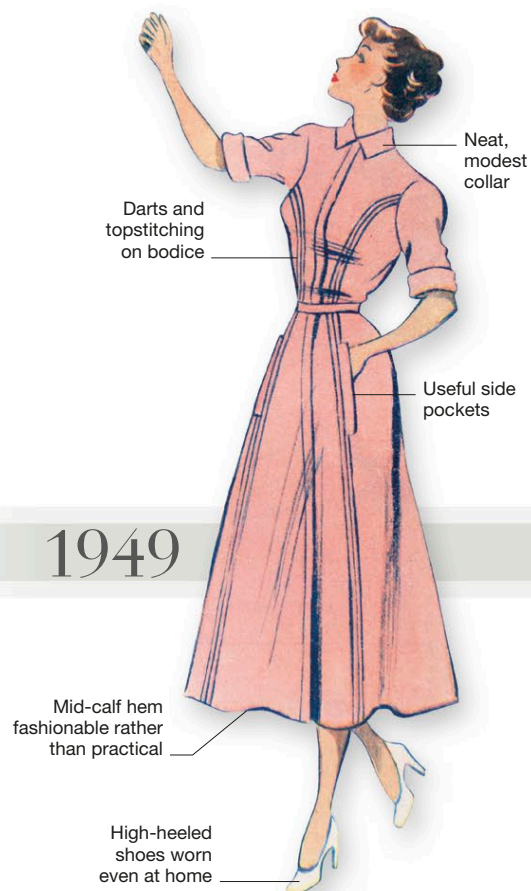


A neat, boxy handbag was one of the most desirable accessories a woman could own. It was usually carried in the hand or in the crook of the arm so that it would not interfere with the line of a dress or suit. The bag generally held a purse, compact and lipstick, handkerchief, small notebook and pencil, and possibly a pair of sunglasses, and had inside pockets for accessories such as gloves.

The height of luxury was a handbag that matched the shoes, though in reality few could afford more than one good bag. Handbags were engineered with a frame and gold-tone clasps at the top to enable a firm and secure closure that also looked smart.



Day dress Samuel Sherman's UK dress company, Sambo, became known for its floral cotton dresses. This style shows the slimmed-down lines, sateen fabric, and bigger, bolder prints that characterized the mid-to-late 1950s.



1949

Pretty in pink Doing housework did not have to mean looking dowdy. As this illustration from French magazine *Votre Mode* shows, the aim was to look stylish and feminine in the home. "A house dress for elegant and practical women," the caption noted.



Abstract prints The talking point of the 1950s was the new art movement, abstract expressionism. Jackson Pollock in particular influenced fashion and interiors. Fabric designers created prints for uses from dresses to curtains.